

MOST CHILDREN SAY THEY MISSED THEIR FRIENDS, WHETHER STUDYING WITH THEM IN THE CLASSROOM OR PLAYING WITH THEM OUTDOORS

playground. The second group of children belonged to those in their formative years of learning who found themselves being denied access to the familiarity, comfort and experience of a classroom. Patel believes Covid would have left a lasting impact on children in both categories. "Our brains develop only as we grow older," she says. "At a very young age, say under 10, it is harder for the mind to understand or accept why one has to stay indoors and not meet friends or teachers." And when these children do meet in-person, the altered context leaves them completely unprepared. Like six-year-old Poorva (*name changed*), who had spoken to her schoolmates only on Zoom, and was horrified when she finally met them in real life at a Christmas party in 2021. Her mother, Sapnaa Malhotra, a 41-year-old homemaker in Mumbai, recounts how her daughter found it so strange to see people from her screen in front of her that she began to cry and stammer. "We had to do a Zoom call and show her that the people at the party were the same as those on the screen. It has been very difficult for a child to grow up in a world where masks and video calls were the norm for two whole years," she says.

The Learning Curb

While the hyper leap to online learning possibly did wonders for the government's digital push in education, like all transitions, and one inspired by necessity to boot, this one too was not without its share of pain. "I found it difficult to concentrate when I was studying online," 12-year-old Shaurya Gupta, a student of the Amity School in Noida, told us. "My grades were still good but I felt I was more productive and happier when I was actually in school." He missed his friends, whether it was studying in the classroom with them, or playing outside.

Educators too found themselves technologically handicapped, and the students struggling with uneven internet connections. Besides, as Radhika Sinha, principal of the Aditya Birla World Academy in Mum-